

Military Aircraft

As the threat of major international conflict receded and the cost of developing all-new military aircraft increased exponentially, because of the hugely complex technology now required, aircraft introductions declined in the 1980s. Many new aircraft were upgraded developments of earlier models—with significant exceptions, such as the European Tornado fighter and the radical US F-117 Nighthawk “Stealth Fighter.”



△ Sea Harrier FRS.1 1980

Origin UK
Engine 21,498 lb (9,751 kg) thrust
Rolls-Royce Pegasus-Mk104 turbofan
Top speed 746 mph (1,200 km/h)

The Naval version of Hawker's brilliant Harrier entered service in 1980, providing air defense for carriers—particularly effectively in the Falklands War, where it was Britain's only fixed-wing fighter.



△ Panavia Tornado GR1 1980

Origin UK/Germany/Italy
Engine 2 x 15,800 lb (7,167 kg) thrust
Rolls-Royce Turbo Union RB199-103 turbofan
Top speed 1,452 mph (2,337 km/h)

Joint European development from the 1970s led to this effective swing-wing multirole fighter with extensive fly-by-wire technology, designed for low-level penetration of enemy defenses.



△ FMA IA 58 Pucará 1980

Origin Argentina
Engine 2 x 1,022 hp Turbomeca
Astazpu XVIG turboprop
Top speed 310 mph (499 km/h)

First developed in the 1960 and 70s, Argentina's ground-attack counter-insurgency aircraft was extensively used in the Falklands War because of its short takeoff and landing (STOL) capability. It remains in service.



△ Tupolev Tu-134 UBL 1981

Origin USSR
Engine 2 x 14,990 lb (6,799 kg)
thrust Soloviev D-30-II turbofan
Top speed 534 mph (860 km/h)

First flown in 1963 the Tu-134 was the first Russian airliner to be widely accepted at western airports. This UBL military version was for bomber aircrew training; 90 were built in Ukraine.

▽ Boeing KC-135R Stratotanker 1980

Origin USA
Engine 4 x 21,634 lb (9,813 kg) thrust
CFM International CFM56 turbofan
Top speed 580 mph (933 km/h)

Developed in the 1950s alongside the 707, this aircraft is still in service for mid-air refueling of bombers and fighter aircraft. From 1980 turbofan engines were fitted to improve economy and load capacity.



▽ Lockheed F-117 Nighthawk 1981

Origin USA
Engine 2 x 10,800 lb (4,989 kg) thrust
General Electric F404-F1D2 turbofan
Top speed 617 mph (993 km/h)

Kept secret until 1988 the F-117 was designed to be undetectable by radar. Built solely for night attacks it would be flown on instruments alone. The Nighthawk used “smart weapons” for ground attack.

